

156-year-old railway junction carrying its name, which were rechristened after Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya, the late BJP ideologue, in August 2018. Then, in October that year, came the big one. Allahabad, the city that was iconic through the freedom struggle and still houses the state's high court, was renamed Prayagraj in 2018. That makeover reportedly cost over Rs 300 crore. A month later, Faizabad and Ayodhya went through a role reversal: Ayodhya used to be in Faizabad, now Faizabad is in Ayodhya. That is, the district is now known after the temple town, not its twin city. While proponents could more persuasively argue that core Hindu symbology is not out of place with Prayagraj and Ayodhya, the logic behind the rechristening of Aligarh is coming in for some hard scrutiny.

Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi, professor of history at AMU, says he has never seen any reference to the name 'Harigarh' in the history of Aligarh. "From whatever sources we have regarding the region's history, Kol or Koil is the only name we get. Till the 19th century, this name was in parlance till it got renamed Aligarh by the British. Earlier, some right-wing outfits had floated this demand, saying the name Aligarh tied it to a Muslim identity. Now it seems the municipal corporation members have joined the bandwagon," he says.

The idea of renaming the city Harigarh took root in the 1960s-70s, says Prof. Mohammad Sajjad from the same department, though his survey of the historical archive also reveals no past name with a religious association. "Kol or Koil is the only past name of Aligarh we know of. In fact, one of the tehsils and a legislative assembly seat is still called Kol. The origins of this name are not clear. In some ancient texts, 'Kol' is referred to in connection with a number of things, such as the name of a tribe or caste, place/mountain, and the moniker for a sage/demon," he says. Anyway, just over 50 years, in the shadow of communal disturbances, certain Hindu organisations began to raise the demand for Harigarh, Sajjad adds. He mentions the book, *Another India: The Making of the World's Largest Muslim Minority, 1947-77*, where Oxford historian Pratinav Anil writes: "When Aligarh Muslim University students decided to conduct relief work in the aftermath of a riot and participate in a dialogue with the Hindu protesters campaigning to rename the town Harigarh, they were prevented from crossing the railway tracks by their circumspect vice-chancellor. Aligarh's [Muslim] townsmen were certainly onto something when they accused university students and staff of retreating into their ivory tower as soon as trouble struck on the other side." The professor refers to the passage to illustrate the point that the university has at times wilted under pressure and not forcefully presented its case.

HISTORIANS SAY 'KOL' OR 'KOIL' IS THE ONLY STABLE NAME IN THE ARCHIVAL RECORD BEFORE THE BRITISH SETTLED ON 'ALIGARH'

BJP councillor Sanjay Pandit, among the first to make the demand in the municipal corporation in 2021, says, "I made this proposal after research. Before it got the name Koil, this region was called Ramgarh. We want the name Harigarh because of Swami Haridas, an Indian spiritual poet and classical musician who was born in the region. Hari is also another name for Lord Vishnu. We have also heard that centuries ago, it was called Harigarh." A similar motion was passed in the zila panchayat last year, he points out. "It has to do with carrying forward our old civilisation and culture, our Hindu traditions," Pandit adds. Prabhat Kumar, history professor at Jamia Millia University, doesn't agree. "Every name has historical relevance. This name-changing business is actually insensitive to tradition," he feels.

It's disputed whether the corporation's proposal got unanimous approval. Samajwadi Party councillor Musharraf Hussain Mazhar claims the resolution was passed using "unfair means"—over half of the Opposition councillors were not present when the BJP section tabled